

Meeting 6: Presenting Findings in a Thesis

Tables, figures, regressions, and the no-screenshots rule
Bachelor Project 2025–2026

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Today's Agenda

1. Where the group landed at A6
2. Patterns across the eight projects
3. How to present findings in a thesis
 - The no-screenshots rule
 - Summary statistics tables
 - Figures and plots
 - Regression tables (OLS and panel)
 - Text-as-data: visuals, tables, validation
 - Survey results: Likert plots, demographics, crosstabs
4. Open floor: bring your current results and your sticking points
5. Looking ahead to A7 (C4 revised + C5 draft)

One plenary today. We work through the presentation rules, then I open the floor to whatever you are stuck on in your own analysis right now.

Where we landed at A6

Four weeks remain to the 25 June deadline. Each of you is at a different stage; everyone needs to close the gap to a finished C4 by A7.

Kinds of output A6 produced

- Panel regressions and ordered logits with controls
- Composite indices on full document sets
- Text classification and dictionary pipelines
- Survey instruments and theory finalised pre-fieldwork

What A7 looks like in every project

- C4 prose around the output you have, however partial
- Each figure or table interpreted via your C2
- Sub-questions answered explicitly in the chapter
- C5 first draft taking shape; word count on the cover

Important

From A7 onward I grade as the final thesis: description vs. analysis, evidence read through your C2, formal quality. The 10,000-word cap is hard.

Patterns across the group

What worked this week

- Movement from design to first empirical evidence
- Null and mixed results reported clearly
- Diagnostics shown explicitly (Cronbach's alpha, Hausman)

Recurring fixes for A7

- Word count on the cover sheet
- Hypotheses written directionally
- Over-firing keyword lists tightened

Read your own RQ before writing C4 and check the analysis answers that exact question.

Presenting findings in a thesis

Tables, figures, regressions, and the conventions examiners expect

The cardinal rule: no screenshots

A screenshot of Stata, R, Python, SPSS, or Excel output does **not** belong in a thesis. Not in the body, not in the appendix.

What I do not want to see

- Cropped R or Python console output pasted as a PNG
- Stata results window screenshots
- Excel cells screenshotted instead of exported
- Default low-resolution figures from a notebook
- Tables typed manually with misaligned columns

What examiners expect

- Tables built with Word's table tools, properly aligned
- Figures exported as PDF or high-resolution PNG
- Every table and figure numbered, captioned, and referenced from the prose
- One source of truth: numbers in the table match the numbers in the text

Important

Screenshots signal that you do not control your own analysis pipeline. They look unprofessional and they will count against you.

Tables: shared anatomy

Every table in your thesis has the same structure. Learn it once.

- **Number and caption above the table:** “Table 1. Summary statistics for the analytical sample (N = 1,987).”
- **No vertical rules.** Three horizontal rules only: above the header, below the header, and at the bottom.
- **Right-align numbers; left-align text labels.** Use the same number of decimal places throughout a column.
- **Units go in the header or row label,** not in every cell. “GDP (log USD)” once, not “USD” on every row.
- **Notes block below the table:** sample, time period, source, and what the significance markers mean.
- **Reference every table from the prose:** “As shown in Table 1, ...”. A table the prose never mentions should not be in the thesis.
- **Order matters:** the prose introduces the table before the reader sees it.

Summary statistics: example

Table 1. Descriptive statistics for the analytical sample.

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Outcome (Y, 0–100 scale)	1,500	54.2	18.7	8.0	96.0
Treatment indicator (X)	1,500	0.34	0.47	0.0	1.0
Composite control (Z)	1,500	0.41	0.23	0.00	1.00
Sub-component 1	1,500	0.48	0.27	0.00	1.00
Sub-component 2	1,500	0.34	0.29	0.00	1.00
Income per capita (log)	1,500	8.42	1.36	5.22	11.78
Age of respondent (years)	1,500	38.6	12.4	18.0	78.0

Notes. Generic illustrative sample. Real notes should give: time period, sources, scaling decisions, and how missing values were handled.

Why this works: every row is legible. Units in headers, not cells. Decimals aligned. Two indented sub-rows show that the composite is broken out. The notes block tells the reader where the data came from.

Figures: anatomy of a good plot

A figure with no axis labels and no title is not a figure, it is a sketch. Every plot in your thesis needs:

- **Title or caption** (one, not both): tells the reader what the figure shows
- **Axis labels with units**, not “x” and “y”
- **Legend** if more than one series; inside the plot area only if it does not occlude data
- **Colour with intent**: group of interest highlighted, comparison group in grey
- **Sample size and source** on the figure or in the caption
- **Exported at high resolution** (PDF or 300 dpi PNG), not the small notebook default

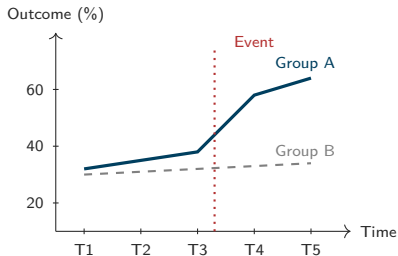


Fig. 1. Outcome by group over time. N = 500.

Regression tables: one table, several models

Table 2. Effect of X on Y: pooled OLS and panel fixed-effects estimates.

	(1) OLS Pooled	(2) OLS + Controls	(3) FE Unit FE	(4) FE Two-way FE
Treatment (X)	-0.182*** (0.041)	-0.124** (0.038)	-0.061* (0.029)	-0.048 (0.031)
Control 1		0.218*** (0.052)	0.176** (0.061)	0.158** (0.058)
Control 2		0.412*** (0.061)	0.188** (0.064)	0.165** (0.062)
Control 3		0.034* (0.014)	0.022 (0.016)	0.019 (0.017)
Unit fixed effects	No	No	Yes	Yes
Time fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	1,500	1,500	1,500	1,500
R ² (within)			0.142	0.168
R ² (overall)	0.082	0.241		

Notes. Generic illustration. SEs in parentheses, clustered by unit in cols. (3)–(4). * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

What to put in a regression table, what to leave out

Always include

- Coefficient, then SE in parentheses underneath
- Significance stars with the threshold defined in the notes
- Sample size (N) for every column
- Goodness-of-fit appropriate to the model (R^2 , pseudo- R^2 , log-likelihood)
- Indicator rows for fixed effects ("Country FE: Yes/No")
- Whether SEs are clustered, and at what level

Almost never include

- The full set of fixed-effects coefficients (173 country dummies)
- Constant terms in FE models (uninterpretable)
- t-statistics *and* SEs (pick one, normally SEs)
- Default software output like "Number of obs read" or "Iter #"
- Coefficients to 6 decimal places

Export the table from your statistical software rather than retyping it. Hand-typing a regression table is how decimals get lost.

Text-as-data: visualising findings

For dictionary methods, supervised classification, topic models, or any document-level scoring, your figures should make the **distribution** and the **change over time** visible.

Useful figure types

- **Frequency over time:** term, category, or topic share by year or by document
- **Score distributions:** boxplot or violin of document-level scores, split by group
- **Heatmap:** categories on one axis, time or source on the other, cell shaded by frequency
- **Coefficient plot** for dictionary categories: point estimate plus 95% CI, one row per category
- **Stacked area** for topic prevalence across the corpus

Avoid

- **Word clouds.** They look pretty and tell the reader almost nothing. Cut them.
- Raw frequency lists with no normalisation by document length
- Single bar chart showing one number per category with no error bars
- Network diagrams without a legend or a clear question they answer

Rule of thumb: if the figure does not change when you swap your data for someone else's, it is not telling the reader anything about your case.

Text-as-data: tables and supporting material

Text projects need a few specific tables that quantitative-only theses do not.

- **Corpus description table:** sources, time period, total documents, total tokens, mean document length. Your equivalent of summary statistics.
- **Coding scheme or dictionary table:** category name, one-line definition, two or three example terms. In the body if short, in the appendix if long.
- **Supervised classification:** precision, recall, F1, and a confusion matrix on the held-out set. One small table is enough.
- **Topic models:** top 10 terms per topic, plus a one-line label you wrote yourself.
- **Validation:** inter-coder agreement or a manual-check accuracy on a random sample.

Important

Quote selectively. A C4 of 30 quoted passages with one sentence of analysis between them is a sourcebook, not a thesis chapter.

Presenting survey results

Survey analysis has its own conventions. The reader needs to know who answered, how many, and what they said.

Standard elements

- **Response rate** and how it was calculated
- **Sample description table:** N, demographics, with population values alongside if available
- **Likert items:** diverging stacked bar (negatives left, positives right), one row per item
- **Group comparisons:** means with 95% CIs, not bare averages
- **Crosstabs:** counts and percentages, with χ^2 and p -value

Avoid

- **Pie charts.** Use a sorted bar chart instead.
- Percentages without N ("67% agreed" on 12 is not the same as on 200)
- Treating a 5-point Likert as continuous without saying so and why
- Causal language from a cross-sectional survey

Description vs. analysis

Description = what you found

- “The treatment group scored 12 points higher on average than the control group.”
- “Outcome Y rose from 44% to 67% between T1 and T5.”
- Patterns, counts, coefficients
- Necessary, but **not sufficient**

Analysis = what it means

- “This pattern is consistent with the mechanism described in [author], where ... drives ...”
- “The direction of the effect supports H1; the magnitude is smaller than [theory] predicts, suggesting ...”
- Connects the evidence to your C2 framework
- This is where the marks are

A table or figure on its own is description. The prose around it is the analysis.

Open floor: bring your current results to the room.

I would like to hear from each of you on at least one of the following:

1. What is the one table or figure you are planning to put in C4 first? What does it show?
2. Where in your analysis are you stuck right now? (Specification, data, interpretation, scope.)
3. Is anything in your output a screenshot rather than a typeset table or exported figure? If so, what do you need to change that?
4. For those running regressions: are your standard errors clustered correctly for your design?
5. For those doing qualitative or text-as-data work: how are you presenting evidence (quotations, coded examples, frequency tables)?

No per-student walk-throughs today. The floor is yours.

For next week (Meeting 7, 4 June)

Submit A7 by Tuesday 2 June at 11:00 via Canvas:

- Chapter 4 (revised): findings as prose, evidence interpreted through C2
- Chapter 5 (first draft):
 - Direct answers to sub-questions and main RQ
 - Implications and one or two recommendations
- Word count on the cover sheet

Important

A7 is the last working submission before the conference (11 June) and the draft manuscript (16 June). Use the C4 prose to lock down the empirical narrative now.

Key references

On research methods and analysis:

- Bryman, A. (2016). *Social Research Methods*, 5th ed. Oxford University Press.
- Creswell, J.W. (2014). *Research Design: Qualitative, Quantitative, and Mixed Methods Approaches*, 4th ed. Sage.

Substantive (digital governance and platform labour):

- van Dijck, J., Poell, T., & de Waal, M. (2018). *The Platform Society*. Oxford University Press.
- Pasquale, F. (2015). *The Black Box Society*. Harvard University Press.

Questions?

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